

Rappaccini's Daughter

Nathaniel Hawthorne · 1844

First published: Democratic Review, Dec 1844

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Mosses_from_an_Old_Manse/Rappaccini's_Daughter (revision 11868101), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Rappaccini's Daughter suggest about science and nature?
- What does Rappaccini's Daughter suggest about love and poison?
- What does Rappaccini's Daughter suggest about innocence?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Rappaccini's Daughter	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*science and nature* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Rappaccini's Daughter

Focus: science that poisons love

Content note (poisoning, death): Sensitive content: Poisoning; death. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes poisoning; death.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Student Giovanni Guasconti, lodging in Padua, watches Beatrice, daughter of the scientist Rappaccini, tend a garden of poisonous plants. He falls in love though her touch and breath kill insects and flowers. Professor Baglioni warns him and gives an antidote. Finding himself poisonous too, Giovanni turns on Beatrice; she drinks the antidote and dies, the poison having been her life. Baglioni cries out at Rappaccini's 'experiment.'

Background: Published in 1844; set in Renaissance Padua, home of Europe's first botanical garden. The garden echoes Eden.

Significance: An early literary warning about scientific ambition, often paired with Frankenstein.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Should scientists ever experiment on people they love? Where are the limits? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes poisoning; death.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are inhaled, blossomed, enticed, assuage, alighting. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "As Beatrice came down the garden path, it was observable that she handled and inhaled the odor of several of the plants which her father had most sedulously avoided." In this sentence it means: breathed in. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Rappaccini's Daughter would have known. Published in 1844; set in Renaissance Padua, home of Europe's first botanical garden. The garden echoes Eden. Why does this story matter? An early literary warning about scientific ambition, often paired with Frankenstein. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for symbolism.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Sometimes he endeavored to assuage the fever of his spirit by a rapid walk through the streets of Padua or beyond its gates: his footsteps kept time with the throbbings of his brain, so that the walk was apt to accelerat" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to science that poisons love? I circle "assuage", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find symbolism, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for symbolism.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of symbolism. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Sometimes he endeavored to assuage the fever of his spirit by a rapid walk through the streets of Padua or beyond its gates: his footsteps kept time with the throbbings of his brain, so that the walk was apt to accelerate itself to a race. One day he found himself arrested; his arm was seized by a portly personage, who had turned back on recognizing the young man and expended much breath in overtaking him.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Symbolism, Allusion, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Rappaccini's Daughter develops the idea of science that poisons love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and allusion shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to science and nature? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about science that poisons love, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how symbolism shapes science that poisons love. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
inhaled (verb)	breathed in	*As Beatrice came down the garden path, it was observable that she handled and inhaled the odor of several of the plants which her father had most sedulously avoided.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
blossomed (verb)	developed; grew and flourished	*But I, dearest Giovanni,--I grew up and blossomed with the plant and was nourished with its breath.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
enticed (verb)	tempted; attracted	*from all the warmth of life and enticed me into thy region of*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
assuage (verb)	cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of	*Sometimes he endeavored to assuage the fever of his spirit by a rapid walk through the streets of Padua or beyond its gates: his footsteps kept time with the throbbings of his brain, so that the walk was apt to accelerate itself to a race.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
alighting (verb)	to come to rest, settle	*Without alighting on the flowers, this winged brightness seemed to be attracted by Beatrice, and lingered in the air and fluttered about her head.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tingling (verb)	prickling or stinging slightly	*When thoroughly aroused, he became sensible of a burning and tingling agony in his hand--in his right hand--the very hand which Beatrice had grasped in her own when he was on the point of plucking one of the gemlike flowers.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cultivating (verb)	foster the growth of	*It was strangely frightful to the young man's imagination to see this air of insecurity in a person cultivating a garden, that most simple and innocent of human toils, and which had been alike the joy and labor of the unfallen parents of the race.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
equanimity (noun)	steadiness of mind under stress	*But now there was a singular and untimely equanimity within his breast.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
alluding (verb)	make a more or less disguised reference to	*"You are a connoisseur in flowers, signor," said Beatrice, with a smile, alluding to the bouquet which he had flung her from the window. "It is no marvel, therefore, if the sight of my father's rare collection has tempted you to take a nearer view.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

apothecary (noun)	a person who prepared and sold medicines and gave medical advice	*"Ay; but my sober imagination does not often play such tricks," said Baglioni; "and, were I to fancy any kind of odor, it would be that of some vile apothecary drug, wherewith my fingers are likely enough to be imbued.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Should scientists ever experiment on people they love? Where are the limits?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with science and nature?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Where does the story take place? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Padua, Italy
2. What is unusual about Beatrice? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She is poisonous to touch and breath
3. Who gives Giovanni the antidote? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Professor Baglioni
4. What happens to Giovanni over time? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He also becomes poisonous
5. What happens when Beatrice drinks the antidote? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She dies
6. Retell the three most important events of “Rappaccini's Daughter” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Student Giovanni Guasconti, lodging in Padua, watches Beatrice, daughter of the scientist Rappaccini, tend a garden of poisonous plants. He falls in love though her touch and breath kill insects and flowers. Professor Baglioni warns him and gives an antidote. Finding himself poisonous too, Giovanni turns on Beatrice; she drinks the antidote and dies, the poison having been her life. Baglioni…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Rappaccini's Daughter”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Rappaccini's Daughter” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “As Beatrice came down the garden path, it was observable that she handled and inhaled the odor of several of the plants which her father had most sedulously avoided.” What does “inhaled” mean here, and

what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: inhaled: breathed in.

10. Reread: “But I, dearest Giovanni,--I grew up and blossomed with the plant and was nourished with its breath.” What does “blossomed” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: blossomed: developed; grew and flourished.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Rappaccini's Daughter” suggest about science that poisons love? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: An early literary warning about scientific ambition, often paired with Frankenstein.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the allusion in this story shape what we understand about science that poisons love? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for references to other books, myths, history or religion.
4. In the passage that begins “Sometimes he endeavored to assuage the fever of his spirit by a rapid walk through the streets of Padua or beyond its gates: his footsteps kept time with the throbbings of his…”, why might Hawthorne have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Rappaccini's Daughter”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Student Giovanni Guasconti, lodging in Padua, watches Beatrice, daughter of the scientist Rappaccini, tend a garden of poisonous plants. He falls in love though her touch and breath kill insects and flowers. Professor Baglioni warns him and gives an antidote. Finding himself poisonous too, Giovanni…
6. As the opening story, what does “Rappaccini's Daughter” set up that the rest of Rappaccini's Daughter will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Should scientists ever experiment on people they love? Where are the limits?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with science and nature? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in 1844; set in Renaissance Padua, home of Europe's first botanical garden. The garden echoes Eden. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "An early literary warning about scientific ambition, often paired with Frankenstein." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "Rappaccini's Daughter" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about science that poisons love? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "Rappaccini's Daughter": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to love and poison: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hawthorne need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "Rappaccini's Daughter" treats science that poisons love with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Rappaccini's Daughter see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve science and nature? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about science that poisons love? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Nathaniel Hawthorne about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Allusion**: references to other books, myths, history or religion
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. Where does the story take place?

   A. Padua, Italy

   B. Florence

C. Venice

D. Rome

2. What is unusual about Beatrice?

A. She is poisonous to touch and breath

B. She cannot speak

C. She is a ghost

D. She is blind

3. Who gives Giovanni the antidote?

A. Professor Baglioni

B. Beatrice

C. Rappaccini

D. Lisabetta

4. What happens to Giovanni over time?

A. He goes blind

B. He forgets Beatrice

C. He becomes immune

D. He also becomes poisonous

5. What happens when Beatrice drinks the antidote?

A. She escapes

B. She is cured

C. She dies

D. She becomes more poisonous

6. In the line "As Beatrice came down the garden path, it was observable that she handled and inhaled the odor of several of the plants which her father had most sedulously avoided.", what does "inhaled" most nearly mean?

A. breathed in

B. tempted; attracted

C. developed; grew and flourished

D. cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of

7. In the line "But I, dearest Giovanni,--I grew up and blossomed with the plant and was nourished with its breath.", what does "blossomed" most nearly mean?

A. cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of

B. developed; grew and flourished

C. tempted; attracted

D. breathed in

Answer key: 1. A (Padua, Italy); 2. A (She is poisonous to touch and breath); 3. A (Professor Baglioni); 4. D (He also becomes poisonous); 5. C (She dies); 6. A (breathed in); 7. B (developed; grew and flourished)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Rappaccini's Daughter,” how does Hawthorne show science that poisons love? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In Rappaccini's Daughter, how does Hawthorne develop the idea of science that poisons love? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Rappaccini's Daughter develops the idea of science that poisons love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and allusion shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Rappaccini's Daughter (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of science that poisons love. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Rappaccini's Daughter suggests about science that poisons love. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and allusion), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Nathaniel Hawthorne uses symbolism in Rappaccini's Daughter to complicate the reader's understanding of science that poisons love. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Rappaccini's Daughter within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of science that poisons love responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Rappaccini's Daughter alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of science that poisons love follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Rappaccini's Daughter and its treatment of science that poisons love. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and allusion, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Rappaccini's Daughter as evidence for a larger claim about science that poisons love in Rappaccini's Daughter. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Rappaccini's Daughter as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of science that poisons love. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Rappaccini's Daughter.

SAT-style questions

1. *from all the warmth of life and enticed me into thy region of*

   As used in the text, what does the word “enticed” most nearly mean?

   A. steadiness of mind under stress

   B. a person who prepared and sold medicines and gave medical advice

   C. make a more or less disguised reference to

   D. tempted; attracted

2. *Sometimes he endeavored to assuage the fever of his spirit by a rapid walk through the streets of Padua or beyond its gates: his footsteps kept time with the throbbings of his brain, so that the walk was apt to accelerate itself to a race. One day he found himself arrested; his arm was seized by a portly personage, who had turned back on recognizing the young man and expended much breath in overtaking him.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Rappaccini's Daughter”?

   A. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

   B. Science that poisons love

   C. Racial pride destroying love

   D. Endurance turning to justice

SAT key: 1. D (tempted; attracted); 2. B (Science that poisons love)

Whole-book test

Rappaccini's Daughter: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Where does the story take place?
   A. Padua, Italy
   B. Florence
   C. Venice
   D. Rome
2. What is unusual about Beatrice?
   A. She is poisonous to touch and breath
   B. She cannot speak
   C. She is a ghost
   D. She is blind
3. Who gives Giovanni the antidote?
   A. Professor Baglioni
   B. Beatrice
   C. Rappaccini
   D. Lisabetta
4. What happens to Giovanni over time?
   A. He goes blind
   B. He forgets Beatrice
   C. He becomes immune
   D. He also becomes poisonous
5. What happens when Beatrice drinks the antidote?
   A. She escapes
   B. She is cured
   C. She dies
   D. She becomes more poisonous
6. In the line “As Beatrice came down the garden path, it was observable that she handled and inhaled the odor of several of the plants which her father had most sedulously avoided.”, what does “inhaled” most nearly mean?
   A. breathed in
   B. tempted; attracted
   C. developed; grew and flourished
   D. cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of

7. In the line “But I, dearest Giovanni,--I grew up and blossomed with the plant and was nourished with its breath.”, what does “blossomed” most nearly mean?
   A. cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of
   B. developed; grew and flourished
   C. tempted; attracted
   D. breathed in
8. As used in the story (“As Beatrice came down the garden path, it was observable that she handled and inhaled the odor of several of the plants which her father had”), what does “inhaled” mean?
   A. breathed in
   B. to come to rest, settle
   C. steadiness of mind under stress
   D. developed; grew and flourished
9. As used in the story (“But I, dearest Giovanni,--I grew up and blossomed with the plant and was nourished with its breath.”), what does “blossomed” mean?
   A. prickling or stinging slightly
   B. developed; grew and flourished
   C. make a more or less disguised reference to
   D. tempted; attracted
10. As used in the story (“from all the warmth of life and enticed me into thy region of”), what does “enticed” mean?
    A. foster the growth of
    B. a person who prepared and sold medicines and gave medical advice
    C. tempted; attracted
    D. cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of
11. As used in the story (“Sometimes he endeavored to assuage the fever of his spirit by a rapid walk through the streets of Padua or beyond its gates: his footsteps k”), what does “assuage” mean?
    A. steadiness of mind under stress
    B. breathed in
    C. to come to rest, settle
    D. cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of
12. As used in the story (“Without alighting on the flowers, this winged brightness seemed to be attracted by Beatrice, and lingered in the air and fluttered about her”), what does “alighting” mean?
    A. to come to rest, settle
    B. make a more or less disguised reference to
    C. developed; grew and flourished
    D. prickling or stinging slightly

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how science and nature develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how love and poison develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how innocence develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (science and nature, love and poison, innocence) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (Padua, Italy); 2. A (She is poisonous to touch and breath); 3. A (Professor Baglioni); 4. D (He also becomes poisonous); 5. C (She dies); 6. A (breathed in); 7. B (developed; grew and flourished); 8. A (breathed in); 9. B (developed; grew and flourished); 10. C (tempted; attracted); 11. D (cause to be more favorably inclined; gain the good will of); 12. A (to come to rest, settle)

Essay assignments

Essay: Science and nature

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rappaccini's Daughter teaches about science and nature. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops science and nature in Rappaccini's Daughter. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops science and nature across Rappaccini's Daughter. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rappaccini's Daughter (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of science and nature. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of science and nature in Rappaccini's Daughter. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in Rappaccini's Daughter (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of science and nature, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rappaccini's Daughter's treatment of science and nature in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on science and nature in Rappaccini's Daughter that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on science and nature in Rappaccini's Daughter. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about science and nature in Rappaccini's Daughter, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on science and nature in Rappaccini's Daughter, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Love and poison

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rappaccini's Daughter teaches about love and poison. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops love and poison in Rappaccini's Daughter. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops love and poison across Rappaccini's Daughter. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rappaccini's Daughter (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of love and poison. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of love and poison in Rappaccini's Daughter. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in Rappaccini's Daughter (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of love and poison, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rappaccini's Daughter's treatment of love and poison in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on love and poison in Rappaccini's Daughter that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on love and poison in Rappaccini's Daughter. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about love and poison in Rappaccini's Daughter, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on love and poison in Rappaccini's Daughter, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Innocence

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rappaccini's Daughter teaches about innocence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops innocence in Rappaccini's Daughter. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops innocence across Rappaccini's Daughter. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rappaccini's Daughter (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of innocence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of innocence in Rappaccini's Daughter. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in Rappaccini's Daughter (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of innocence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rappaccini's Daughter's treatment of innocence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on innocence in Rappaccini's Daughter that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on innocence in Rappaccini's Daughter. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about innocence in Rappaccini's Daughter, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on innocence in Rappaccini's Daughter, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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